

The Sound of Harlem

Grades 5–8 • Music • Yellow Level

Yellow Level: Grade Level

Name: _____ Date: _____ Period: _____

Context: Jazz emerged from the collision of African musical traditions (call-and-response, polyrhythm, improvisation, blue notes) with American instruments and urban energy. Understanding its structure reveals why it sounded so new — and why it was so powerful.

ACTIVITY 1: COMPARE TWO RECORDINGS

Blues vs Big Band Jazz

Your teacher will play two recordings. Complete the comparison as you listen:

Element	Blues recording	Big band jazz recording
Instruments heard		
Tempo (speed)		
Mood / emotion		
Solo or ensemble?		
Call-and-response present?		
Can you hear improvisation?		

What do these two recordings share — despite sounding so different?

ACTIVITY 2: STRUCTURAL ANALYSIS — 12-BAR BLUES

The 12-bar blues uses three chords in a repeating sequence: **I (4 bars) → IV (2 bars) → I (2 bars) → V (1 bar) → IV (1 bar) → I (1 bar) → V (1 bar)**

Why does a repeating harmonic structure make improvisation easier, not harder?

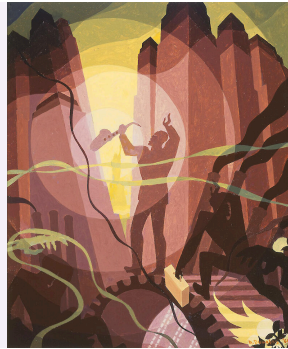
Syncopation means accenting the off-beat — the "and" between beats. Why do you think this rhythmic technique feels more energetic than playing exactly on the beat?

Yellow Level: Grade Level**ACTIVITY 3: AFRICAN ROOTS PARAGRAPH****Where Did Jazz Come From?**

Jazz did not appear from nowhere. Write a paragraph (5–6 sentences) connecting the musical structures you've analysed to their African roots. Use at least three of these terms: *call-and-response*, *polyrhythm*, *improvisation*, *griot tradition*, *blue notes*, *work songs*.

ACTIVITY 4: ART AND MUSIC

Aaron Douglas painted *Song of the Towers* (below) in 1934 — the same year Duke Ellington recorded "Sophisticated Lady." Both are about Harlem's creative energy.



Aaron Douglas — *Song of the Towers*, 1934. Note the concentric circles — Douglas said they represented sound waves.

What specific musical element do you think the concentric circles represent? What about the figure with the saxophone?

Mini Museum Connection

The **Jazz Lab** lets you build a jazz arrangement by layering instruments. Try building the same melody in both a blues style and a big band style. What changes — and what stays the same?

minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance